

MariaDB: The Community-Developed Fork of MySQL



MariaDB is a community-developed fork of the MySQL relational database management system and is guaranteed to remain free. This article targets application developers who use an RDBMS day in and day out, and any technology enthusiast who loves to know about new technologies, especially in the open source world.

Whether you are a well-established professional from the computer applications world, or a budding computer science student, you are probably familiar with MariaDB, the new entrant in the world of RDBMS. So let's try to define MariaDB. When you read about it, you actually find various people defining it differently.

So I thought of defining it from two perspectives:

- **Historical definition:** Specifying the origin and history behind it
- **Technical definition:** Specifying what its technical capabilities are for users and developers

Historically, MariaDB is a fork of MySQL, the world's most well-known RDBMS. MariaDB was started by the founder of MySQL (Monty Widenius) in 2009, with the intention of keeping it open source and improving community contribution, which went down notably after the multiple acquisitions of MySQL — first by Sun Microsystems and then by Oracle.

Technically, MariaDB is a fork/branch of MySQL that provides backward compatibility and drop-in replacement for MySQL, with a better and more enhanced set of features compared to the equivalent MySQL release.

Scope and special features of MariaDB

Monty Widenius started MariaDB with a very specific mandate:

- Import all new code from the MySQL branch and then enhance it to make it more stable
- Clean up MySQL code
- Add and encourage more community contributions
- Develop its own storage engine
- Add more new features, including third party software

Installation

Where does one find MariaDB and how do we install it?

From 2015, MariaDB has been adopted by all major Linux distributions such as Ubuntu, SUSE, Red Hat and Debian in their software repositories. Apart from these, specific versions can be downloaded from the MariaDB download page <https://downloads.mariadb.org/> and from all over the Internet.

Installing MariaDB

There are many ways to install MariaDB. If you have some distribution's MariaDB repository configured, then you can use a distribution-specific installer; for example, for Red Hat or Fedora, you can use Yum, as follows: